

CURRENT AFFAIRS WEEKLY

25 AUGUST 2026

COVERAGE WINDOW: 16 AUGUST 2026 TO 24 AUGUST 2026

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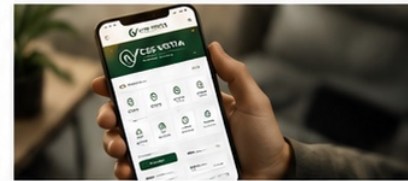
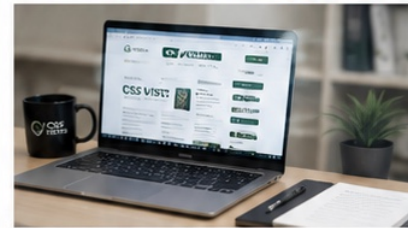
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TOP DEVELOPMENTS OF THE WEEK

- ✓ Defence Architecture Reforms: New Laws Enacted
- ✓ Moody's Upgrades Pakistan's Sovereign Rating to B3
- ✓ Pakistan Mediates in Iran-US Crisis
- ✓ Pakistan Assumes UN Disarmament Conference Presidency
- ✓ Pakistan-Syria Relations Rebuilt
- ✓ Counterterrorism Operations Intensify and much more...



TRUSTED CONTENT
VERIFIED & AUTHENTIC



EXAM FOCUSED
ANALYTICAL & IN-DEPTH



SUCCESS ORIENTED
YOUR GOAL, OUR MISSION

EMPOWERING ASPIRANTS. BUILDING FUTURES.

PLATFORM FEATURE

CSS VISTA PLATFORM IS OFFICIALLY LAUNCHED

Pakistan's all-in-one digital ecosystem
for competitive-exam preparation goes live.

After months of dedicated effort, research, and development, CSS VISTA has officially launched to empower aspirants with authentic content, smart tools, and exam-oriented guidance—all in one integrated platform.



WHAT CSS VISTA OFFERS

- ✓ All CSS Subjects MCQs
- ✓ CSS MPT & GK Mocks
- ✓ Past Papers & Analysis
- ✓ Weekly Current Affairs Journal
- ✓ Notes & Samples
- ✓ Test Series & Evaluation
- ✓ Study Planner & Tools
- ✓ Topic-wise Practice



WHY IT MATTERS

- One platform for complete exam preparation.
- Verified, authentic, and aspirant-focused content.
- Structured tools to build concepts, practice, and performance.
- Accessible anytime, anywhere—designed for serious learners.

“One platform.
Every resource.
Endless success.”



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the impact of digital learning platforms on competitive exam preparation in Pakistan.
- 2 How can technology-driven platforms contribute to merit and transparency in the examination system?
- 3 Evaluate the role of structured digital resources in enhancing aspirants' performance and confidence.



PAKISTAN ANGLE

CSS VISTA is a Pakistan-based initiative dedicated to improving the quality, access, and seriousness of exam preparation for aspirants across the country.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- CSS VISTA official website
- CSS VISTA official announcements
- CSS VISTA official social media



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PAKISTAN / GOVERNANCE & STRATEGY

PAKISTAN'S HIGHER DEFENCE ARCHITECTURE RECAST

On 20 August 2026, Pakistan enacted the **Defence Forces Act 2026** and amendments to the National Command Authority Act 2010, introducing a new defence coordination framework, strengthening the role of the Chief of Defence Forces, and recalibrating strategic command structures.

“20 August 2026 — major defence-command legislation enacted.”



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

Parliament passed the Defence Forces Act 2026 and amendments to the National Command Authority Act 2010 on 20 August 2026. The legislation creates a new defence coordination framework, formalises the post of Chief of Defence Forces (CDF), and streamlines strategic decision-making within the national security architecture.



BACKGROUND

The National Command Authority (NCA), established under the NCA Act 2010, is responsible for the country's nuclear command, control and communications. Over time, the need for greater integration among the armed services and unified strategic planning led to the creation of a broader statutory framework through the Defence Forces Act 2026.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Establishes a unified defence coordination framework for policy coherence.
- Strengthens the role of the Chief of Defence Forces as the principal military adviser and coordinator.
- Enhances joint planning, interoperability and resource optimisation across services.
- Carries implications for civil-military coordination and strategic governance.



STRATEGIC DIMENSION

- Institutionalises integrated strategic planning and joint operational oversight.
- Improves responsiveness to emerging security challenges in a dynamic regional environment.
- Reinforces credible minimum deterrence through more cohesive command and control arrangements.
- Supports long-term reforms in force modernisation and capability development.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss the key provisions and objectives of the Defence Forces Act 2026.
- How do the recent amendments to the National Command Authority Act 2010 impact Pakistan's strategic command and control architecture?
- Examine the implications of creating the post of Chief of Defence Forces for civil-military relations and strategic governance in Pakistan.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- National Assembly of Pakistan
- Senate of Pakistan
- Reuters / Arab News

PAKISTAN / ECONOMY

Pakistan's Economic Signal Improves

Moody's upgraded Pakistan's sovereign rating to B3 from Caa1 with a stable outlook on 24 August 2026, citing improving governance and easing external vulnerabilities.

The development comes alongside signs of external sector stabilization, with the current-account deficit narrowing to \$328 million in July 2026.

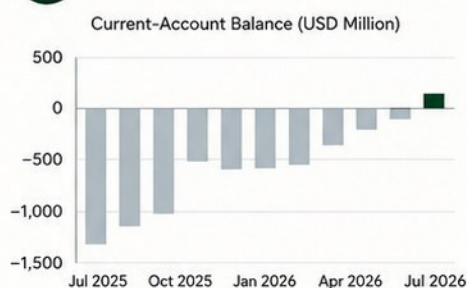


LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Moody's Ratings upgraded Pakistan's sovereign credit rating to B3 from Caa1.
- Outlook: Stable.
- Date: 24 August 2026.
- The upgrade reflects improving governance and easing external vulnerabilities.
- Structural reforms remain necessary to strengthen growth and fiscal resilience.



KEY ECONOMIC INDICATORS



Moody's
Rating

B3



Outlook

Stable



July Current-
Account Deficit

**\$328
million**



WHY IT MATTERS

- Enhances investor confidence and may lower borrowing costs.
- Reflects policy continuity, fiscal discipline, and external-sector improvement.
- Supports access to international capital markets and financial stability.
- Encourages long-term investment and sustainable growth.



RISKS AND CHALLENGES

- Global economic uncertainty and rising protectionism.
- Commodity price volatility and climate-related shocks.
- High public debt and interest burden.
- Weak tax base and fiscal rigidities.
- Need for deeper structural reforms in governance and SOEs.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- External buffers are improving, but remain below comfort.
- Exports and remittances are key to sustaining stability.
- Reform focus: tax-to-GDP ratio, energy sector, and governance.
- Continued engagement with IMF and creditors is vital.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- What factors led to Moody's upgrade of Pakistan's rating?
- How does a current-account deficit impact an economy?
- What reforms are essential for sustaining economic stability in Pakistan?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Moody's Ratings
- State Bank of Pakistan
- Dawn / Reuters





PAKISTAN / FOREIGN POLICY

PAKISTAN'S MEDIATION ROLE IN THE IRAN-U.S. CRISIS

On 24 August 2026, Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir arrived in Tehran as Pakistan intensified efforts to support de-escalation in the Iran-U.S. crisis. This issue records developments only through 24 August.



Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir in Tehran on 24 August 2026 as Pakistan pursued regional de-escalation.



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- On 24 August 2026, Munir arrived in Tehran for high-level engagements. air
- Pakistan conveyed messages to both Iran and the United States, urging restraint and renewed dialogue.
- Islamabad offered to support dialogue channels and confidence-building measures.



KEY ACTORS

- Pakistan** – Facilitator and bridge-builder.
- Iran** – Seeks de-escalation and protection of interests.
- United States** – Focused on regional security and non-proliferation.
- Gulf States** – Concerned about stability, trade, and energy flows.

THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ: A CRITICAL CHOKEPOINT



About one-fifth of global petroleum liquids consumption normally transits the Strait of Hormuz.

any disruption impacts global energy markets.



WHY IT MATTERS

- The Iran-U.S. crisis has implications for Gulf stability, global oil markets, and international shipping.
- Escalation risks could trigger energy price shocks and wider regional conflict.
- Pakistan's proactive role enhances its diplomatic profile and contributes to regional peace.

- The Strait of Hormuz is one of the world's most important oil and LNG chokepoints.

- The Strait of Hormuz handles nearly 20% of the world's oil trade.
- Any disruption can spike oil prices and affect global inflation.
- Gulf stability is vital for energy security and economic growth in the region and beyond.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan sought de-escalation and peaceful dialogue.
- Stability in the Gulf supports Pakistan's economy, remittances, and energy security.
- Balanced diplomacy reflects Pakistan's stance of independent foreign policy and regional connectivity.



FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- If dialogue succeeds, it can reduce tensions and ensure uninterrupted oil flows.
- Pakistan can emerge as a trusted mediator and peace contributor.
- Failure to de-escalate may lead to regional instability and economic volatility.

“De-escalation diplomacy matters when regional conflict threatens global energy routes.”



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss Pakistan's mediation role in the Iran-U.S. crisis and its regional implications.
- How does the Strait of Hormuz impact global energy security?
- Evaluate the significance of Pakistan's balanced diplomacy in promoting stability in the Gulf region.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Reuters
- Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Pakistan



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PAKISTAN / MULTILATERAL DIPLOMACY

PAKISTAN AT THE U.N. CONFERENCE ON DISARMAMENT

Pakistan assumed the presidency of the United Nations Conference on Disarmament (CD) in Geneva in August 2026.

On Pakistan's behalf, Ambassador Tahir Hussain Andrabi presided over meetings during the final presidency of the 2026 session, guiding discussions on multilateral arms control, nuclear disarmament, and the prevention of arms races.



 Venue:
Geneva

 Institution:
Conference on
Disarmament

 Pakistan presidency:
August 2026



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

Pakistan held the presidency of the Conference on Disarmament (CD) in Geneva during August 2026. Ambassador Tahir Hussain Andrabi chaired formal meetings, consultations, and interactive dialogues, fostering consensus on strengthening multilateral disarmament frameworks.



BACKGROUND

- The Conference on Disarmament is the world's single multilateral disarmament negotiating body.
- Established in 1979, it operates by consensus and addresses a wide range of arms control issues.
- Pakistan has consistently supported disarmament, non-proliferation, and peaceful uses of technology.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Multilateral arms control is vital for international peace and security.
- Nuclear disarmament remains the highest priority in global disarmament efforts.
- Preventing arms races reduces strategic instability and enhances global trust.
- Strengthens the rules-based international order and cooperative security.



STRATEGIC RELEVANCE

- Enhances Pakistan's profile as a responsible stakeholder in global peace and security.
- Provides a platform to advocate for nuclear disarmament and the universality of NPT.
- Reinforces Pakistan's consistent position against discriminatory regimes.
- Builds partnerships with like-minded states on disarmament priorities.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan reaffirms its principled stance for complete nuclear disarmament, elimination of all WMDs, and a balanced approach to disarmament.
- Stresses non-discrimination, transparency, and verifiability in arms control regimes.
- Advocates for equitable participation of all states in disarmament decision-making.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the role and significance of the Conference on Disarmament.
- 2 What is Pakistan's position on nuclear disarmament and arms control?
- 3 How does Pakistan's presidency of the CD in 2026 reflect its diplomatic priorities?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Ministry of Foreign Affairs Pakistan
- UN Geneva

“ Disarmament is not just an aspiration; it is a necessity for a peaceful and secure world. ”



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PAKISTAN / DIPLOMACY

PAKISTAN-SYRIA RELATIONS ENTER A NEW PHASE

Syrian Foreign Minister Asaad Hassan Al-Shaibani visited Pakistan on 19–20 August 2026 — the first visit by a Syrian foreign minister to Pakistan following the formation of Syria's new government.

The visit opened discussion on diplomatic cooperation, economic links, and regional engagement.



19–20
AUGUST
2026



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Syrian FM Asaad Hassan Al-Shaibani visited Pakistan on 19–20 August 2026.
- Met with Deputy Prime Minister / Foreign Minister of Pakistan.
- Talks focused on diplomatic cooperation, economic ties, and regional engagement.



BACKGROUND

- Syria's new government was formed in early 2026.
- This visit marks the first high-level diplomatic engagement by Syria with Pakistan in recent years.
- Both countries share historic ties rooted in solidarity and mutual respect.



KEY AREAS OF COOPERATION

- Restoration and strengthening of diplomatic relations.
- Trade and investment opportunities.
- Capacity building and technical cooperation.
- Coordination on regional and international issues.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Reopens channels of dialogue between two brotherly Muslim countries.
- Supports Syria's reintegration with the international community.
- Enhances Pakistan's diplomatic outreach in the Middle East.
- Creates opportunities for economic engagement and people-to-people contacts.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan welcomes Syria's new government.
- Committed to supporting Syria's stability, reconstruction, and development.
- Seeks peaceful, sovereign, and prosperous Syria.

BILATERAL TIMELINE

- **1947–2011**
Warm brotherly relations and diplomatic ties.
- **2012–2025**
Limited engagement due to regional developments.
- **19–20 AUGUST 2026**
Syrian FM's visit to Pakistan — first since the formation of Syria's new government.
- **A NEW CHAPTER**
Commitment to build stronger diplomatic, economic, and people-to-people ties.



FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- Potential exchange of high-level visits.
- Expansion of trade, education, and health cooperation.
- Collaboration in multilateral forums.
- Stronger role in promoting peace and stability in the region.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Pakistan
- Reuters



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the significance of the Syrian Foreign Minister's visit to Pakistan.
- 2 What are the key areas of cooperation between Pakistan and Syria?
- 3 How can Pakistan contribute to Syria's reconstruction and stability?



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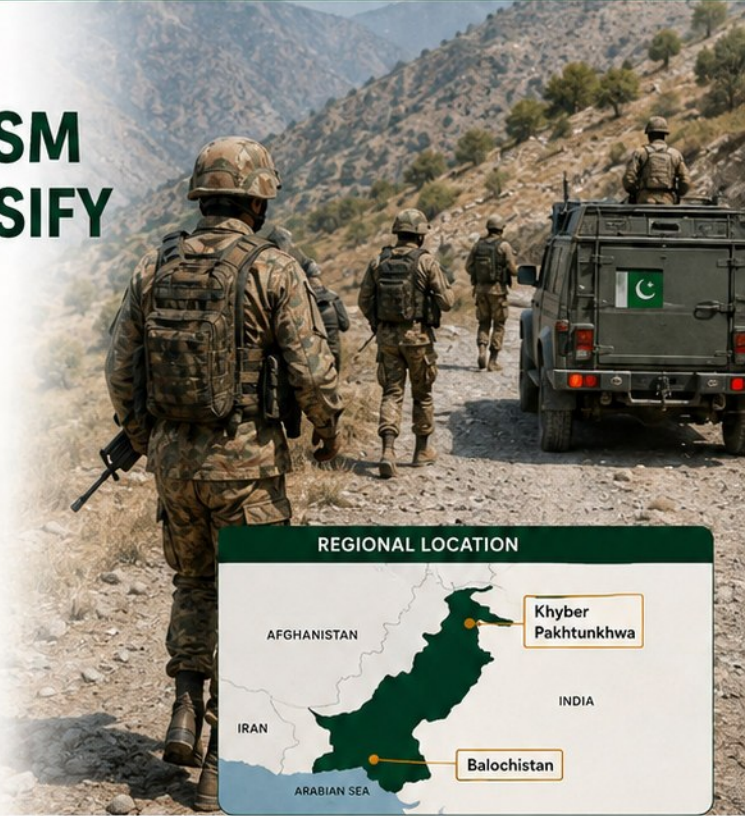




PAKISTAN / INTERNAL SECURITY

COUNTERTERRORISM OPERATIONS INTENSIFY

Security forces, in joint intelligence-based operations with police, killed 49 militants in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan in August 2026, highlighting the persistence of Pakistan's internal-security challenge.




49
militants
killed


Areas:
KP &
Balochistan

REGIONAL LOCATION



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- In August 2026, security forces, in joint intelligence-based operations with police, killed 49 militants in KP and Balochistan.
- The operations targeted hideouts and movement networks of militant groups involved in attacks on security personnel and civilians.



SECURITY CONTEXT

- Militants continue to exploit rugged terrain and cross-border sanctuaries.
- Attacks on security convoys, check posts, and public venues persist.
- KP and Balochistan remain the most affected provinces, facing complex security and governance challenges.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Reflects continuing counterterrorism efforts and the state's commitment to protect citizens.
- Underscores the need for long-term stabilization, intelligence coordination, and governance in affected areas.



STRATEGIC AND GOVERNANCE IMPLICATIONS

- Strengthening joint operations, intelligence fusion, and real-time information sharing is critical.
- Durable peace requires development, rule of law, and service delivery in vulnerable districts.
- Regional cooperation and border management are essential to disrupt militant support networks.



CHALLENGES

- Safe havens across the border and mobility of militant networks.
- Resource constraints and capacity gaps in remote areas.
- Need to balance kinetic operations with political outreach and socio-economic development.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Assess the security situation in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan. What are the key drivers of militancy in these regions?
- 2 Examine Pakistan's counterterrorism strategy. How can intelligence coordination be improved?
- 3 Discuss the role of governance and development in countering militancy and ensuring long-term stability.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR)
- Radio Pakistan / Business Recorder
- Reuters



PAKISTAN / YOUTH & DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

YOUTH POLICY AND PAKISTAN'S DIGITAL FUTURE

The federal cabinet approved in principle the National Adolescent and Youth Policy in August 2026—paving the way for an empowered, skilled, and future-ready generation.



AT A GLANCE

-  **150,000**
Google Career Certificates
-  **AI Centre of Excellence:**
Islamabad
-  **Free AI tools for**
Pakistani students:
1 year



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- The Federal Cabinet, in August 2026, approved in principle the National Adolescent and Youth Policy.
- The policy sets a unified roadmap to empower youth through education, skills, innovation, and inclusion in Pakistan's digital economy.



WHAT THE POLICY SEEKS

- Promote quality education and digital literacy for all.
- Build future-ready skills aligned with modern industry needs.
- Encourage youth entrepreneurship and innovation.
- Ensure inclusion, gender equality, and equal opportunities.
- Strengthen youth participation in national development.



PAKISTAN-GOOGLE COOPERATION

A major step towards a digitally empowered Pakistan:

- 150,000 Google Career Certificates for Pakistanis in 2026.
- One-year free access to advanced Google AI tools for Pakistani university students.
- Establishment of an AI Centre of Excellence in Islamabad to drive research, talent development, and innovation.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Equips young Pakistanis with in-demand digital and AI skills.
- Strengthens employability and entrepreneurship.
- Positions Pakistan as a regional hub for digital innovation.
- Supports inclusive growth and a knowledge-based economy.



OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES

Opportunities

- Demographic dividend and growing digital economy.
- Global partnerships bringing skills, tools, and investment.
- Innovation and startups solving local problems.

Challenges

- Digital divide and unequal access to technology.
- Need for quality infrastructure and teacher training.
- Ensuring inclusivity for women and marginalized youth.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss the key features and objectives of Pakistan's National Adolescent and Youth Policy (2026).
- How will the Pakistan-Google partnership contribute to youth empowerment and digital transformation?
- Evaluate the opportunities and challenges of building an AI-driven economy in Pakistan.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- APP / Federal Cabinet reporting
- Prime Minister's Office
- Google / Business Recorder / Dawn



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PAKISTAN / CLIMATE & DISASTER GOVERNANCE

MONSOON EMERGENCY AND CLIMATE VULNERABILITY

During the 16–24 August 2026 period, fresh heavy rainfall, flooding and flash-flood risks deepened Pakistan's monsoon emergency, underscoring climate vulnerability and the governance challenge of disaster preparedness and response.



NDMA situation reports monitored deaths, injuries and damage across provinces.



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Rainfall intensity increased across multiple regions, triggering floods and flash floods.
- NDMA and provincial authorities remained on high alert; relief and rescue operations were scaled up.
- Evacuations, relief camps, and health emergency measures were activated.



CLIMATE CONTEXT

- Warmer atmosphere holds more moisture, intensifying extreme rainfall.
- Glacial melt, land-use change and deforestation heighten flood and landslide risk.
- Monsoon variability is increasing under climate change.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Human safety, livelihoods, and food security are at risk.
- Repeated disasters erode development gains and strain public finances.
- Highlights the urgent need for adaptation and risk-informed planning.



MONSOON IMPACT AT A GLANCE (16–24 AUGUST 2026)



HEAVY RAINFALL

Widespread spells across KP, Punjab, Balochistan, AJK & GB.



FLOODING

Rivers in spate; low-lying areas inundated.



FLASH FLOOD RISK

High in hill torrents and urban nullahs; landslides reported.



DAMAGE & LOSSES

Homes, roads, crops, livestock and power infrastructure hit.

Note: Figures are provisional and subject to change as assessments continue.



GOVERNANCE CHALLENGE

- Early warning must reach last-mile communities on time.
- Coordination across federal, provincial and district levels is critical.
- Preparedness, logistics, and post-disaster rehabilitation need strengthening.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- NDMA and disaster authorities tracked casualties and damage.
- Relief efforts prioritized vulnerable districts and critical infrastructure.
- The week reinforced the need for resilient infrastructure, forecasting, and adaptation.



FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- Invest in climate-resilient infrastructure (drainage, embankments, bridges).
- Strengthen hydromet forecasting, community alerts, and risk communication.
- Mainstream climate risk in planning, building codes, and land-use policies.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the impact of intensified monsoon events on Pakistan.
- 2 How can disaster governance be strengthened at local and national levels?
- 3 Examine the role of early warning systems in reducing flood risks.
- 4 What adaptation measures are essential for climate-vulnerable regions?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- NDMA
- Reuters / Arab News



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PAKISTAN / DEMOCRACY & DEVOLUTION

PUNJAB'S LOCAL GOVERNMENT ELECTIONS BACK ON THE AGENDA

In August 2026, Punjab moved toward long-delayed local government elections, with reporting indicating phased polls could be held between 15 December 2026 and 15 January 2027.



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Punjab government has signalled a renewed push for local government (LG) elections.
- Reporting suggests phased elections could be held between 15 December 2026 and 15 January 2027.
- The move aims to fulfill legal mandates and strengthen grassroots governance.



BACKGROUND

- Local government elections in Punjab have faced repeated delays over the past decade.
- The Punjab Local Government Act, 2013 provides the legal framework for elected local councils.
- The Constitution (18th Amendment) assigns local government as a devolved subject, to be strengthened over time.



WHY LOCAL GOVERNMENT MATTERS

- Central to devolution, bringing decision-making closer to citizens.
- Improves service delivery in areas like water, sanitation, roads, education, and health.
- Enhances citizen participation, inclusion, and democratic accountability.
- Builds a leadership pipeline and strengthens social cohesion at the grassroots.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss the significance of local government elections in strengthening democracy in Pakistan.
- Examine the constitutional and legal framework for devolution in Pakistan.
- What are the challenges to effective local governance in Pakistan and how can they be addressed?

PROPOSED ELECTION WINDOW



**15 DEC 2026 –
15 JAN 2027**

Phased local government elections across Punjab



GOVERNANCE DIMENSION

- Devolution:** Empowers local institutions to plan and implement development according to local needs.
- Accountability:** Elected bodies are answerable to citizens, improving transparency and oversight.
- Participation:** Encourages women, youth, and marginalized groups to take part in local governance.
- Efficiency:** Local councils can respond faster to community issues and optimize resource use.



CHALLENGES

- Political consensus and timely electoral rolls remain critical.
- Capacity constraints and limited fiscal devolution to local bodies.
- Risk of elite capture and weak oversight mechanisms.
- Ensuring fair delimitation, transparency, and women's meaningful representation.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Business Recorder (August 2026)
- Punjab government / provincial reporting (August 2026)



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PAKISTAN / DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

PAKISTAN AND GOOGLE PARTNER FOR AN AI-DRIVEN FUTURE

Pakistan and Google signed an MoU this week to deepen cooperation in digital skills, AI, education, digital payments, and technology-driven government transformation.



150,000
Google Career
Certificates for
Pakistani youth
in 2026



One-year free access
for Pakistani students
to advanced Google
AI tools including
Google AI Plus and
Gemini



**AI Centre of
Excellence**
planned in
Islamabad



MoU to accelerate
innovation, digital
adoption, and
inclusive economic
growth



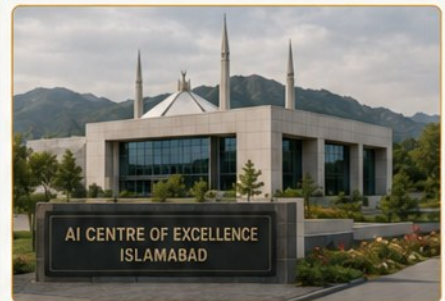
LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Pakistan and Google signed an MoU to strengthen cooperation across digital skills, AI, education, digital payments, and technology-driven government transformation.
- 150,000 Google Career Certificates will be provided to Pakistani learners in 2026.
- Pakistani students will receive one-year free access to Google AI Plus and Gemini.
- An AI Centre of Excellence will be established in Islamabad to drive research, innovation, and capacity building.



KEY FEATURES OF THE PARTNERSHIP

- Digital Skills:** Large-scale upskilling through Google Career Certificates and training programs.
- AI Access:** Free access to advanced AI tools for students to foster innovation and learning.
- Education:** Support for educators, digital literacy, and modern learning resources.
- Digital Payments:** Collaboration to promote secure, inclusive, and innovative digital payments.
- Government Transformation:** AI-enabled solutions to improve public service delivery and efficiency.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Prepares Pakistani youth with future-ready skills in AI and digital technologies.
- Bridges the digital divide and promotes inclusive opportunities.
- Supports Pakistan's vision for a knowledge-based economy and global competitiveness.
- Enhances efficiency, transparency, and innovation in public sector services.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Aligns with Pakistan's Digital Pakistan and National AI Policy initiatives.
- Strengthens human capital and empowers the youth for high-value jobs.
- Encourages local innovation, startups, and tech entrepreneurship.
- Positions Pakistan as a regional hub for AI research and digital solutions.



OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES

Opportunities:

- Massive upskilling and employability
- Stricter digital economy and fintech growth
- Attraction of tech investment and innovation

Challenges:

- Ensuring equitable access across regions
- Bridging gender and socio-economic gaps
- Strengthening data privacy and cybersecurity



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss the significance of Pakistan-Google partnership for digital transformation.
- How will 150,000 Google Career Certificates benefit Pakistani youth and economy?
- Examine the role of AI and digital skills in achieving Pakistan's development goals.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Ministry of IT & Telecom, Government of Pakistan
- Official MoU announcement (August 2026)
- Google Pakistan Official Blog / Press Release



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INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / MIDDLE EAST SECURITY

IRAN-U.S. CONFRONTATION AND THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ RISK

During 16–24 August 2026, confrontation between Iran and the United States remained a major international crisis. Risks around the Strait of Hormuz raised alarm as nearly one-fifth of global oil flows pass through this strategic chokepoint. Sanctions pressure, maritime insecurity, and de-escalation diplomacy all shaped the evolving crisis.



“ Nearly 20% of global oil consumption flows through the Strait of Hormuz. ”



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Tensions between Iran and the U.S. escalated through military posturing, sanctions threats, and maritime incidents in and around the Persian Gulf.
- Iran warned against any attempt to restrict its maritime rights, while the U.S. strengthened naval presence with regional partners.
- Multiple tankers reported GPS interference and electronic jamming in the Gulf.
- Diplomatic efforts by regional mediators continued to prevent further escalation.



BACKGROUND

- The Strait of Hormuz, just 33 km wide at its narrowest point, is the world's most critical energy chokepoint.
- Nearly one-fifth of global oil and a significant share of LNG trade pass through it.
- Iran–U.S. hostility is rooted in nuclear disputes, sanctions, regional rivalries, and strategic competition.
- Iran has previously threatened to disrupt shipping in the Strait during periods of heightened tension.



GLOBAL ENERGY DIMENSION

- Oil price volatility increased amid fears of disruption to supply routes.
- Energy-importing economies face inflationary pressures and higher transport costs.
- Strategic petroleum reserves and supply diversification remain key responses.
- Global markets are pricing in risk premiums linked to Gulf instability.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Disruption in the Strait could spike oil prices, fuel inflation, and slow global growth.
- Risks to shipping and energy security undermine investor confidence.
- Gulf instability can trigger wider regional conflicts and refugee flows.
- Critical sea lanes are vital for global trade, including Pakistan's energy and exports.



REGIONAL SECURITY DIMENSION

- Heightened military deployments by the U.S. and regional states increase the risk of miscalculation.
- Non-state actors could exploit instability to target shipping and energy infrastructure.
- Fragile ceasefires and proxy tensions in the region complicate de-escalation.
- Continued diplomacy, confidence-building, and crisis communication channels are essential.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan relies on Gulf energy imports; any disruption raises costs and pressures balance of payments.
- Shipping risks affect trade flows and insurance premiums.
- Pakistan supports diplomacy, freedom of navigation, and de-escalation.
- Diversifying energy sources and building strategic reserves are prudent priorities.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the strategic and economic significance of the Strait of Hormuz.
- 2 Analyze how the Iran–U.S. confrontation impacts global energy markets and inflation.
- 3 Examine Pakistan's vulnerabilities and policy options in the event of disruption in the Strait of Hormuz.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- International Energy Agency (IEA)
- U.S. Department of State
- Reuters / Associated Press
- Al Jazeera
- Pakistan Ministry of Foreign Affairs



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INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / GLOBAL ECONOMY AND STRATEGY

THE IRAN CRISIS: GLOBAL ECONOMIC SHOCKS AND REGIONAL IMPLICATIONS

The continuing U.S.-Israeli war with Iran and insecurity around Gulf shipping kept energy markets, insurance costs and regional confidence under pressure. For Pakistan, the main channels are imported-energy costs, inflation, the current account and shipping risk.



ECONOMIC IMPACT

Key economic channels at risk

Channel	Risk Trigger	Impact
Oil Prices	Threat to supply via Hormuz Strait	Higher import bills, inflationary pressures worldwide
Market Confidence	Geopolitical uncertainty	Volatility in global markets, capital outflows
Maritime Security	Attacks, seizures, insurance hikes	Higher shipping costs, trade disruptions
Global Growth	Tighter energy supply & higher costs	Slower growth, recession risks
Fiscal Pressure	Costlier fuel & subsidy burden	Wider fiscal deficits in import-dependent economies

VERIFIED ECONOMIC TRANSMISSION CHANNELS

- Energy prices: risk premiums can lift import costs.
- Shipping: disruption raises freight and war-risk insurance.
- Inflation: higher fuel costs can pass through to transport and food.
- Current account: a larger petroleum bill can widen external financing needs.

Markets uncertainty can weaken investment and business confidence.



OIL SUPPLY ROUTES AT RISK

Strait of Hormuz: The Chokepoint



STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS

- Redrawing of regional alignments and security partnerships.
- Arms race and escalation spiral in the Middle East.
- Stronger military footprint by external powers in the Gulf.
- Increased use of non-state actors and asymmetric tactics.
- Risk of conflict spillover into Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, and Yemen.



PAKISTAN ANGLE

- Higher oil prices worsen current account deficit and fuel import bill.
- Inflationary pressures cut real incomes and dampen growth.
- Rising shipping and insurance costs hit trade competitiveness.
- Gulf instability affects remittances, jobs, and investor confidence.
- External debt servicing becomes more costly.



Global powers urge restraint, but diplomatic off-ramps remain uncertain.



CHALLENGES TO DE-ESCALATION

- Deep mistrust and zero-sum rivalries.
- Domestic political compulsions in key states.
- Breakdown of nuclear and regional security dialogues.
- Sanctions, counter-sanctions, and proxy conflicts.
- Information warfare and miscalculation risks.



FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- Persistent volatility in energy markets.
- Supply chain realignments and higher costs.
- Acceleration of energy transition and diversification policies.
- Greater push for regional security architectures.
- Pakistan must hedge risks through diversification, efficiency, and strategic partnerships.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the global economic impacts of the Iran crisis.
- 2 How does the Strait of Hormuz affect global energy security?
- 3 Examine the implications of the Iran crisis for Pakistan's economy.
- 4 What diplomatic or strategic options exist to de-escalate the crisis?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- International Energy Agency (IEA)
- U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA)
- UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD)
- IMF – World Economic Outlook (August 2026)
- Reuters / Bloomberg / Al Jazeera





INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / MIDDLE EAST

GAZA PEACE DIPLOMACY STALLS DESPITE RENEWED TALKS

During the week, renewed high-level diplomatic contacts aimed at ending the Gaza conflict failed to produce a breakthrough. Core disputes remained over disarmament, Israeli withdrawal, governance arrangements, security guarantees, and the implementation of a U.S.-backed framework.



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- High-level talks, including shuttle diplomacy and multilateral consultations, were held during the week.
- No agreement was reached as positions remained far apart.
- Mediators will continue consultations in the coming days.



BACKGROUND

- The conflict escalated in October 2023, leading to widespread destruction in Gaza.
- Multiple ceasefire efforts and a U.S.-backed framework have been proposed.
- Core disputes persist over disarmament, Israeli troop withdrawal, governance, and implementation mechanisms.



KEY OBSTACLES

- Disarmament of armed groups.
- Extent and sequencing of Israeli withdrawal.
- Governance and security arrangements post-conflict.
- Implementation, monitoring, and enforcement mechanism.
- Mutual distrust and political constraints on both sides.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Impacts regional stability and the risk of wider escalation.
- Implications for international law and protection of civilians.
- Affects humanitarian conditions and reconstruction.
- Central to Muslim-world diplomacy and public sentiment.



HUMANITARIAN DIMENSION

- Humanitarian needs in Gaza remain extreme.
- Access for aid, medical supplies, clean water, and fuel is limited.
- Displacement, food insecurity, and public health risks continue to rise.



REGIONAL AND INTERNATIONAL DIMENSION

- Regional actors are engaged in mediation and confidence-building.
- Major powers back different proposals, complicating consensus.
- UN and international organizations urge immediate de-escalation and humanitarian access.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan consistently calls for an immediate ceasefire, protection of civilians, and unhindered humanitarian aid.
- Reaffirms support for a just, lasting, and comprehensive peace based on international law and relevant UN resolutions.
- Advocates a two-state solution for durable peace.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the reasons behind the failure of renewed peace talks on Gaza.
- 2 How does the Gaza conflict affect regional stability and international law?
- 3 What role can Pakistan and the Muslim world play in advancing a just peace in Gaza?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- United Nations (UN)
- Reuters
- Al Jazeera
- Foreign Office of Pakistan





INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / EUROPEAN SECURITY

EUROPE DEEPENS SUPPORT FOR UKRAINE

On 24 August 2026, the European Union approved another €6.1 billion in military assistance for Ukraine, reaffirming its unwavering commitment as the war continues and diplomatic efforts remain deadlocked. The decision underscores Europe's determination to uphold sovereignty, deter aggression, and defend the rules-based international order.

€6.1 BILLION
MILITARY ASSISTANCE
FOR UKRAINE
APPROVED ON
24 AUGUST 2026



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- The EU approved an additional €6.1 billion in military assistance for Ukraine on 24 August 2026.
- The package will fund ammunition, air defence systems, artillery, drones, maintenance, and training.
- It complements the EU's €50 billion Ukraine Facility (2024–2027) and existing European Peace Facility support.



BACKGROUND

- Since Russia's full-scale invasion in February 2022, the EU and its member states have provided over €150 billion in political, financial, humanitarian, and military aid.
- Previous tranches under the European Peace Facility have enabled Ukraine to sustain its defence, protect civilians, and maintain critical infrastructure.
- Diplomatic deadlock persists, with no breakthrough in ceasefire or negotiations.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Ukraine's defence sustains the frontline, protects civilians, and preserves sovereignty.
- Deterrence:** Denies Russia military gains and raises the cost of continued aggression.
- European security:** Instability in Ukraine would embolden revisionist powers.
- International order:** Upholds the UN Charter, sovereignty, and territorial integrity.



STRATEGIC DIMENSION

- Sustained assistance strengthens Ukraine's defensive depth and operational resilience.
- Ensures continuity in critical capabilities (air defence, artillery, drones, ISR).
- Supports long-term deterrence by denying coercion and rewarding aggression.
- Reinforces Europe's integrated security architecture and crisis preparedness.



EUROPEAN DIMENSION

- Strengthens Europe's role as a security provider in its neighbourhood.
- Reinforces transatlantic unity and complements NATO's collective support.
- Signals long-term European resolve to deter aggression and prevent territorial revisionism.
- Enhances burden-sharing and reduces over-reliance on any single ally.
- Supports defence industry cooperation, innovation, and strategic autonomy.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Discuss how it contributes to global economic and energy stability, vital for Pakistan's trade and remittances.
- Upholding sovereignty and peaceful dispute resolution aligns with Pakistan's principled foreign policy.
- Opportunities for defence industry learning, technology transfer, and participation in humanitarian & reconstruction efforts.



FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- Continued European aid will help Ukraine sustain defence and strengthen negotiation leverage.
- War's persistence may prolong economic and energy volatility globally.
- Successful deterrence can restore confidence in the rules-based international order.
- Post-war reconstruction will require long-term European investment and institutional partnerships.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss the significance of the EU's €6.1 billion military assistance to Ukraine.
- Examine the role of the European Union in shaping post-war security architecture in Europe.
- How does the Ukraine war impact global order, energy security, and economic stability?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- European Union – Council of the EU (Press Release, 24 August 2026)
- European Commission
- Reuters / Associated Press
- BBC / Al Jazeera



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INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / GLOBAL TRADE

U.S.–CANADA TRADE TENSIONS ESCALATE

Failed negotiations and sharply higher U.S. tariffs announced during the week have escalated trade tensions with Canada, raising concerns for integrated North American supply chains and the wider global trading system.



“ Tariffs up, talks down, uncertainty up — markets and supply chains feel the shock. ”

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- After negotiations faltered, new U.S. tariffs of 50% on about \$20bn of Canadian goods took effect on 24 August 2026.
- Canada prepared retaliatory measures while both sides signalled that the dispute could widen.
- The confrontation raises questions about integrated supply chains and the future of USMCA.



BACKGROUND

- The U.S.–Canada trade relationship is one of the world's most integrated, supported by the USMCA.
- Key dispute areas: rules of origin in autos, supply management in dairy, timber, digital services tax, and clean energy incentives.
- Rising protectionist pressures in the U.S. have led to demands for “fairer” trade terms and tariff realignments.

NORTH AMERICAN TRADE WHY THE DISPUTE MATTERS

- Canada and the U.S. have deeply integrated automotive and industrial supply chains.
- Tariffs can raise input costs on both sides of the border.
- The dispute creates uncertainty ahead of the next USMCA review cycle.
- Retaliation can spill into steel, vehicles, dairy and other politically sensitive sectors.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Statistics Canada



WHY IT MATTERS

- North America's prosperity rests on deep trade interdependence.
- Tariffs raise costs, disrupt just-in-time production, and reduce competitiveness.
- Escalation risks inflation, slower growth, and job losses on both sides.
- Sets a worrying precedent for a wider retreat from open, rules-based trade.



TRADE & SUPPLY-CHAIN IMPACT

- Auto sector most exposed due to complex cross-border parts and assembly.
- Higher input costs for steel, aluminum, lumber, and agri-food.
- Logistics delays and re-routing add costs and uncertainty.
- Firms may diversify suppliers, but transition costs will be high.



MULTILATERAL DIMENSION

- Escalation risks undermining WTO principles of non-discrimination and binding commitments.
- Retaliatory spirals can weaken the rules-based multilateral trading system.
- Other countries may face pressure to take sides or adopt similar protectionist measures.



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Disruptions in North American trade can reorder global supply chains.
- Opportunities for selective export gains in textiles, engineering, and agri-food if buyers diversify.
- Rising protectionism can tighten access to key markets and increase compliance costs.
- Pakistan should deepen FTAs, enhance standards compliance, and improve logistics competitiveness.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the causes and consequences of escalating U.S.–Canada trade tensions in the context of protectionism.
- 2 Evaluate the impact of higher U.S. tariffs on North American supply chains and economic interdependence.
- 3 Examine the potential WTO implications of rising bilateral protectionism and its effect on the rules-based trading system.



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Office of the United States Trade Representative (USTR)
- Global Affairs Canada
- U.S. Census Bureau
- Statistics Canada
- World Trade Organization (WTO)



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INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / NUCLEAR SAFEGUARDS

SYRIA OPENS FORMER NUCLEAR SITES TO IAEA SCRUTINY

In August 2026, Syria granted unprecedented access to International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) inspectors to former nuclear-related sites, marking a significant step toward clarifying concerns surrounding an undeclared Assad-era nuclear programme, with implications for safeguards credibility and Middle East security.



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Syria has allowed IAEA inspectors access to former nuclear sites, including locations linked in past reports to a covert nuclear programme.
- The cooperation includes environmental sampling, site inspections, and provision of documentation.
- Damascus has affirmed its commitment to the NPT and full cooperation with the IAEA.



BACKGROUND

- Since the mid-2000s, the IAEA and Western states alleged Syria operated an undeclared nuclear programme, including a reactor at Al-Kibar (Deir ez-Zor), destroyed in 2007.
- Syria denied the allegations and was referred to the UN Security Council.
- With the political transition in late 2024, Damascus signaled openness to re-engagement and transparency.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Enhances transparency and helps clarify past proliferation concerns.
- Strengthens the global non-proliferation regime and safeguards credibility.
- Reduces regional suspicions and may contribute to de-escalation.
- Sets a precedent for other opaque programmes to consider verification.



NUCLEAR NON-PROLIFERATION DIMENSION

- Syria's cooperation reinforces the universality of the NPT and IAEA safeguards.
- Supports the IAEA's ability to resolve outstanding safeguards issues.
- Demonstrates the benefits of diplomacy and verification over confrontation.



REGIONAL SECURITY DIMENSION

- Clarifies a long-standing source of tension between Syria and regional actors.
- May open space for broader security dialogue in the Middle East.
- Reduces the risk of proliferation spillovers and miscalculation.

IAEA SAFEGUARDS FOCUS

- Syria agreed to broader IAEA access to resolve outstanding safeguards questions.
- The Dair Alzour site remains central to the Agency's long-running assessment.
- Environmental sampling, site access and documentation are key verification tools.
- The new cooperation could help clarify the historical record and strengthen safeguards confidence.



= Former Nuclear-Related Site



PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan strongly supports nuclear non-proliferation, peaceful uses of nuclear energy, and IAEA safeguards.
- A stable, non-proliferated Middle East aligns with Pakistan's security and development interests.
- Enhances prospects for regional cooperation on energy, trade and connectivity.



FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- Full accounting and resolution of outstanding issues will be key.
- Continued cooperation could lead to safeguards implementation agreement.
- Positive momentum may encourage confidence-building and regional confidence measures.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Analyze the significance of Syria's decision to open former nuclear sites to the IAEA.
- 2 Discuss the role of the IAEA in strengthening the global non-proliferation regime.
- 3 How can transparency in the Middle East contribute to regional peace and security?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- IAEA Official Statements (August 2026)
- UN Security Council Documents
- Reuters / BBC News (August 2026)
- Arms Control Association (ACA)
- SIPRI / IISS Reports





INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / INTERNATIONAL LAW

U.S. SANCTIONS THE INTERNATIONAL CRIMINAL COURT LEADERSHIP

During the week of 16–24 August 2026, the United States imposed sanctions on International Criminal Court (ICC) President Tomoko Akane and senior lawyer Abdoulaye Seye, escalating its long-standing dispute with the Court over jurisdiction, sovereignty and accountability.



Cour
Pénale
Internationale
International
Criminal
Court

“Sanctions target ICC President Tomoko Akane and lawyer Abdoulaye Seye, deepening the standoff over international justice and state sovereignty.”

• On 18 August 2026, the United States sanctioned ICC President Tomoko Akane and senior trial lawyer Abdoulaye Seye.

Tomoko Akane and senior lawyer Abdoulaye Seye under Executive Order 14203.

- The sanctions include asset freezes, travel bans to the U.S., and prohibitions on transactions with U.S. persons.
- The move follows ICC actions related to investigations involving U.S. allies and personnel.



BACKGROUND

- The ICC, established by the Rome Statute (1998) and operational since 2002, is an independent tribunal that prosecutes genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes, and the crime of aggression.
- The U.S. is not a party to the Rome Statute and has consistently opposed what it views as overreach into matters concerning non-member states and nationals.
- Previous U.S. measures include the 2002 “American Service-Members’ Protection Act” and past sanctions on ICC officials.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Raises fundamental questions about sovereignty vs. accountability.
- Risks undermining the authority and deterrent effect of international justice mechanisms.
- Reflects geopolitical contestation over the limits of international legal institutions.



INTERNATIONAL LAW DIMENSION

- Article 16 of the Rome Statute allows UN Security Council deferrals, but the U.S. position lies outside the Statute.
- Sanctions do not negate ICC jurisdiction but may impede cooperation, evidence gathering, and enforcement.
- Highlights tension between universal justice and state non-consent.



INSTITUTIONAL INDEPENDENCE

- Targeting the leadership of an independent judicial institution undermines judicial independence and the rule of law.
- Sets a concerning precedent for politicization of international institutions.
- May discourage states and witnesses from cooperating with the ICC.



GLOBAL IMPLICATIONS

- Could deepen global polarization on international justice.
- May push states to form alternative legal or political alignments.
- Risks weakening norms against impunity for grave international crimes.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1 Discuss the legal basis and implications of the U.S. sanctions on ICC officials.
- 2 Critically examine the balance between state sovereignty and international criminal jurisdiction.
- 3 What impact do political pressures have on the effectiveness of international legal institutions such as the ICC?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- U.S. Department of the Treasury (20 August 2026)
- International Criminal Court (ICC) Statements
- Reuters / AP / BBC News
- UN News



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INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / FOOD SECURITY

BLACK SEA ATTACKS DISRUPT GRAIN EXPORTS

Attacks on port facilities and cargo ships in the Black Sea have disrupted Russian and Ukrainian grain exports, pushing up global wheat prices and raising concerns for import-dependent states across Asia, the Middle East, and Africa.



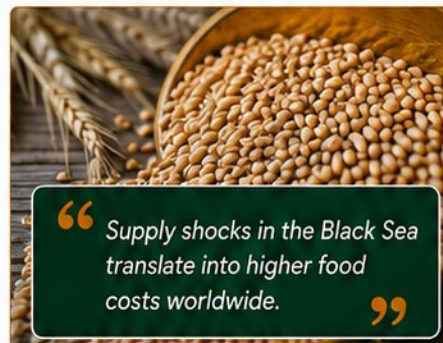
LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- Recent attacks on Black Sea ports and grain infrastructure have disrupted loading operations and shipping routes.
- Several grain vessels have either been damaged or rerouted, causing delays in deliveries.
- Global wheat prices have risen sharply in response to supply uncertainties.

BLACK SEA GRAIN EXPORTS AT RISK



Disruptions to key routes threaten global wheat supplies and increase transportation costs.



“Supply shocks in the Black Sea translate into higher food costs worldwide.”



BACKGROUND

- The Black Sea region, led by Russia and Ukraine, supplies nearly 30% of global wheat exports.
- The grain corridor agreements of 2022–2023 helped stabilize markets after the Ukraine war.
- Continued hostilities and attacks on maritime infrastructure have undermined export reliability.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Wheat is a staple for billions of people in Asia, Africa, and the Middle East.
- Disruptions can lead to higher food inflation and social unrest in vulnerable economies.
- Food insecurity may widen inequality and strain government budgets.



GLOBAL FOOD-SECURITY DIMENSION

- Import-dependent countries face higher costs and uncertain supply.
- The UN FAO and WFP have warned of worsening food insecurity in fragile states.
- Alternative suppliers (e.g., EU, USA, India, Australia) may not fully offset the shortfall.
- Insurance and freight costs for grain shipments have surged.

PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- Pakistan remains primarily dependent on domestic wheat production; import needs vary by harvest and policy conditions.
- Black Sea price shocks can still affect import-parity prices, food inflation and procurement decisions.
- Higher global freight and insurance costs can raise the cost of any required imports.
- Reserves, crop productivity and diversified sourcing remain important food-security buffers.



FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- Prolonged disruptions may lead to long-term shifts in global grain trade routes.
- Countries will invest more in food-resilience, local production, and strategic stockpiles.
- Geopolitical tensions could keep food markets volatile in the near term.



LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss the impact of Black Sea disruptions on global food security.
- How does the Russia-Ukraine conflict affect wheat exports and global prices?
- What strategies can import-dependent countries like Pakistan adopt to ensure food security?



VERIFIED SOURCES

- Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO)
- World Food Programme (WFP)
- International Grains Council (IGC)
- Reuters / Al Jazeera
- Business Recorder (August 2026)



Visit: www.css-vista.com





INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS / ASIAN GEOPOLITICS

CHINA-INDIA RELATIONS SHOW SIGNS OF A STRATEGIC THAW

Ahead of the BRICS summit, renewed boundary diplomacy and the prospect of Xi Jinping's first India visit in seven years suggest a cautious thaw in China-India ties with wide-ranging implications for Asian geopolitics, BRICS politics, border stability, and Pakistan's strategic environment.



BRICS

NEW DELHI 2026

12-13 SEPTEMBER



LATEST DEVELOPMENT

- India is preparing to host the BRICS summit in New Delhi on 12-13 September 2026.
- Reuters reported that Xi Jinping was likely to attend with a large delegation; plans were still being finalised as of 24 August.
- The prospective visit would be Xi's first to India in seven years and would signal a cautious bilateral thaw.
- expected to attend; his first India visit in seven years is under consideration.

BACKGROUND

- China-India relations deteriorated sharply after the Galwan Valley clash in June 2020.
- Over 50,000 troops were deployed on both sides, disrupting trade, travel and people-to-people ties.
- Gradual disengagement in 2024-25 and reopening of communication channels have laid the groundwork for a cautious reset.



WHY IT MATTERS

- Reduces risk of military escalation along the world's highest unresolved border.
- Opens space for trade, connectivity and regional economic cooperation.
- Supports multipolarity by strengthening BRICS and Global South cooperation.
- Enhances regional stability in South Asia and the Indo-Pacific.

STRATEGIC DIMENSION

- Both states seek strategic stability while managing competition.
- Economic interdependence remains significant despite trust deficit.
- Boundary management, crisis communication and CBMs are central to long-term normalization.
- India's balancing strategy between Quad partnerships and BRICS/Shanghai Cooperation engagement continues.

REGIONAL IMPLICATIONS

- A stable China-India relationship can strengthen Asian connectivity and energy security.
- May reduce external alignments driven by rivalry and foster cooperative regionalism.
- Impacts power equations in the Indian Ocean, Central Asia, and South Asia.

PAKISTAN PERSPECTIVE

- China-India thaw could reduce external pressure on the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) environment.
- Improved regional stability supports Pakistan's economic and connectivity interests.
- Pakistan must deepen strategic ties with China while pursuing balanced diplomacy with India for regional peace.

FUTURE IMPLICATIONS

- If sustained, the thaw could lead to gradual boundary settlement talks.
- Increased cooperation in climate, trade and health may follow.
- Failure to address core disputes could reverse gains.
- India visit by Xi Jinping would be a landmark step toward normalization.

LIKELY EXAM QUESTIONS

- Discuss the significance of the recent China-India diplomatic thaw.
- What are the strategic and regional implications of improved China-India ties?
- How does the China-India thaw affect Pakistan's strategic environment?

VERIFIED SOURCES

- Ministry of External Affairs, India
- Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses (IDSA)
- International Crisis Group
- Ministry of Foreign Affairs, China
- Reuters / Associated Press
- South China Morning Post



WEEK AT A GLANCE

DAY-BY-DAY CURRENT AFFAIRS

AUGUST 16	SUNDAY	Regional security concerns rise as developments around the Iran crisis and the Strait of Hormuz keep global energy markets on edge.
AUGUST 17	MONDAY	Gaza diplomacy continues without a breakthrough, with core disputes still blocking a durable ceasefire framework.
AUGUST 18	TUESDAY	Pakistan and Google advance digital cooperation, including skills, AI and education-related initiatives for students and youth.
AUGUST 19	WEDNESDAY	Syria's Foreign Minister arrives in Pakistan, opening a new phase of bilateral engagement after the formation of Syria's new government.
AUGUST 20	THURSDAY	Pakistan enacts the Defence Forces Act 2026 and related amendments, reshaping higher defence and strategic command structures.
AUGUST 21	FRIDAY	Security forces intensify counterterrorism operations in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan, highlighting persistent internal-security challenges.
AUGUST 22	SATURDAY	Monsoon and weather alerts remained active across several regions, while relief and preparedness measures continued.
AUGUST 23	SUNDAY	Monsoon rains, flooding and climate vulnerability remain central concerns as disaster preparedness and resilience stay in focus.
AUGUST 24	MONDAY	Moody's upgrades Pakistan's sovereign rating to B3; the EU approves new support for Ukraine; and global attention remains fixed on the Iran-related crisis and Black Sea disruptions.



KEY THEMES OF THE WEEK



GOVERNANCE



ECONOMY



DIGITAL
TRANSFORMATION



DIPLOMACY



SECURITY



CLIMATE



GLOBAL
TRADE



VERIFIED SOURCES

Information verified from official statements, Ministry of Foreign Affairs Pakistan, NDMA, SBP, Moody's, Reuters, EU institutions and other credible sources.



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